Swami Bhakti Ballabha Tirtha Maharaj

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Appearance and Youth

Srila Bhakti Ballabha Tirtha Maharaj was a disciple and the successor of Srila Bhakti Dayita Madhava Goswami Maharaj, and acharya of the Sri Chaitanya Gaudiya Math. He appeared in 1924 in Assam, on Rama Navami, the day on which Lord Ramachandra appeared[1]. His worldly name was Kamakhya Charan Guha-Ray, his father's Dhirendra Guha-Ray; at initiation he became Krishna Ballabha Brahmachari, and on accepting sannyasa, Tridandi Swami Bhakti Ballabha Tirtha Maharaj.

He grew up in a pious setting; his search for truth led him to Calcutta University and to philosophy, and in 1947 he took his master's degree in philosophy.

Meeting His Guru

That same year, 1947, in Goalpara in Assam, in the house of Radha Mohan, he first saw Srila Bhakti Dayita Madhava, and the sadhu's divine and powerful presence drew him at once. He came with a friend, Devavrata (Rabi), with questions about the path to the Lord; when he bowed before the sadhu for the first time, his hair stood on end — he felt blessed. He confessed that while chanting the Name he felt he might see the Lord at any moment — and would then have to leave home and those he loved; this worry made him stop chanting. The guru praised the question to encourage him and answered with the parable of the geese and the swan.

Radha Mohan — "Ram Mohan-da", a disciple of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta who worked as a clerk for the young man's uncle — became his vartma-pradarshaka-guru: he brought him to the Gaudiya Math and bore opposition and reproach for it. Gurudeva's letters to Kamakhya were sent care of Radha Mohan, and Radha Mohan's kind wife and whole family did much for him. On his guru's advice he read Srila Bhaktivinoda's "Jaiva-dharma", and his doubts dispersed. The guru wrote to him: on the path of nivritti government service is not needed; on the path of pravritti, take it. Understanding that pure service was impossible at home, he resolved to leave home.

Serving His Guru

From then on he devoted himself wholly to serving his guru, and soon became secretary of the Sri Chaitanya Gaudiya Math, which had more than twenty ashrams in India. In 1961 he accepted sannyasa, becoming one of Srila Bhakti Dayita Madhava's first sannyasi disciples. Shortly before 1965 Srila A. C. Bhaktivedanta Swami asked him to come with him to America; but he was serving his guru as secretary of the math and humbly declined.

The journal "Sri Chaitanya Vani" printed an eyewitness account, by a disciple of Srila Bhakti Dayita Madhava, of the first festival at Jashra after the temple of Jagadisha Pandita passed to their guru: thousands were fed with mahaprasad, and the narrator admits that he still cannot recall that day without a thrill. The biography does not name him; perhaps it was Tirtha Maharaj himself, the journal's editor. From his guru's mother he heard stories of his guru's childhood. On 30 December 1978 he asked Gurudeva to give instructions to a Western devotee from Chandigarh. In those last instructions the guru said that Tirtha Maharaj could not always be on the spot, and so entrusted the management of the math to Jagamohan Prabhu.

Acharya of the Sri Chaitanya Gaudiya Math

By a letter of 12 December 1976 Srila Bhakti Dayita Madhava appointed him president and acharya of the Sri Chaitanya Gaudiya Math after himself, and on 30 December 1978, after consulting his senior godbrothers, again announced him as his successor. After his guru's departure in 1979 he became acharya of the math.

He was blessed by, and closely associated with, many prominent disciples of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta — Srila Bhakti Pramoda Puri, Srila Bhakti Hridaya Bon, Srila B. R. Sridhar Maharaj, Akinchana Krishnadasa Babaji and others. He named Srila Bhakti Pramoda Puri Maharaj as his shiksha-guru, and honoured all the disciples of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta as shiksha-gurus too.

Preaching

For some five decades he preached the teaching of Sri Chaitanya — against violence and cruelty, for the unity of hearts beyond differences of race, creed and religion. From 1997, at Srila Bhakti Pramoda Puri's request, he spent several months a year travelling the world and preached in Great Britain, Holland, France, Spain, Italy, Austria, Germany, Slovenia, Russia, Ukraine, Australia, Singapore, Malaysia, Indonesia, Hawaii and throughout the United States.

In 1997 in New York he spoke at the World Peace Prayer Society at the United Nations and at the World Conference on Religion and Peace, setting out a path to peace on Vedic principles. He held conversations with theologians — Catholic and Protestant, Jewish, Hindu and Baha'i — — at universities, interfaith gatherings, churches, temples and centres; he spoke on radio and television, and in 2000 gave an interview to the BBC that was broadcast worldwide. In 1997 he founded GOKUL — the Global Organization of Krishnachaitanya's Universal Love — and became its acharya; he was also vice-president of the World Vaishnava Association.

He worked eighteen hours a day, tirelessly bringing people Vedic wisdom and the teaching of bhakti-yoga. Srila Bhakti Pramoda Puri Maharaj wrote in 1992 that even at seventy[2] he edited a journal, wrote books and managed the Chaitanya Gaudiya Maths throughout India, "from the Himalayas to Cape Comorin"; in his tirelessness Puri Maharaj saw a sign of mercy from the Lord, from the guru and from the Vaishnavas, and prayed for his long life. People were drawn by his gentle and loving nature, his firm faith in guru, Vaishnavas and Bhagavan, his extraordinary kirtan and his heartfelt talks.

Writings

In Bengali he composed a commentary on Dhruva's life, a Vraja-parikrama guidebook, an account of the rules of Deity worship, and a two-volume life of his guru. He edited the Sri Chaitanya Gaudiya Math's monthly "Sri Chaitanya Vani" (its chief editor and president was Srila Bhakti Pramoda Puri); there the life of his guru and his sketches of the Lord's associates appeared in instalments, the latter later coming out in Bengali as two volumes. The Bengali edition was printed by Bhakti Varidhi Parivrajaka Maharaj; Srila Bhakti Pramoda Puri edited the text and added information. He dedicated the book to his "beloved gurudeva", Srila Bhakti Dayita Madhava, and to his "deeply revered shiksha-guru", Srila Bhakti Pramoda Puri, who also inspired the English edition, for devotees everywhere. He wrote articles and books in English as well as in his mother tongues: in English appeared his books "Suddha Bhakti", "Sages of Ancient India" and "A Taste of Transcendence", and in 2001 the English edition of those same biographies (on the title page, "Swami B. B. Tirtha").

In his foreword to these biographies Srila Bhakti Pramoda Puri wrote that he had collected information on the devotees' lives from many sources and made it sweeter still by his own insight; he tells with delight of Jagannatha Mishra, of Madhavendra Puri and Ishvara Puri, of Advaita Acharya, Shrivasa Pandita, Chandrashekhara Acharya, Pundarika Vidyanidhi, Gadadhara Pandita, Vakreshvara Pandita, Gadadhara Dasa, Shivananda Sena, Paramananda Puri, Murari Gupta and a great many others, and in

these stories, Puri Maharaj says, every letter is soaked in devotion's nectar. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta called the printing press the "brihat-mridanga", the great drum; and Puri Maharaj wrote that Bhakti Varidhi Parivrajaka Maharaj and Tirtha Maharaj, by giving book publishing a large place in the math's service, win the affection of their gurus and of all pure devotees — those of the past and those yet to come.

In his introduction to them he writes that the articles were gathered into one book in the hope of helping devotees relish the deeds of the Lord's associates. Mahaprabhu's associates are transcendental and are understood only by their mercy; to one who has not surrendered to the Lord these mysteries are closed, and even among the surrendered the capacity to see the devotees' glory varies. A soul covered by anarthas cannot grasp the glory of Vishnu and His devotees, and its praise turns into disrespect; yet if one glorifies them humbly and prayerfully, aware of one's own unworthiness, the Vaishnavas will forgive the flaws, and their pleased glance frees one from anarthas. A pure devotee is rare, and to meet one is great good fortune. He recalls the words of the "Sri Chaitanya-charitamrita": "Whoever constantly remembers the Guru, God and the holy Vaishnavas will easily attain the fulfilment of his innermost desires and overcome every difficulty and obstacle". (CC, Adi 1.21) And further: every perfection comes by the Vaishnavas' mercy, and a soul that glorifies the qualities of devotees is — as he heard from his guru and from sadhus — liberated.

The Six Goswamis, he recalls, bowed to the Vaishnavas thousands of times each day, and every day one should give time to remembering the Vaishnavas; an important part of service is to observe their days of appearance and departure — to remember them, to pray for their mercy and to sing their glories in kirtan. The Sri Chaitanya Gaudiya Math publishes a Vaishnava calendar with these days every year, and his book is meant to help those who remember and glorify the Vaishnavas, though for many associates neither the tithi, nor the year, nor the birthplace, nor the parents' names are known. We glorify them to be rid of all that leads away from service and to gain attachment to Krishna; and even if we see no change in ourselves, the Vaishnavas' feet remain the fallen souls' sole shelter. He allows that some readers may find the book's language not poetic enough, thanks Srila Bhakti Pramoda Puri, whose blessings encouraged him in this service, and all who helped, and at the end bows to his Gurudeva, "who purifies the fallen", to his parama-gurudeva Srila Bhaktisiddhanta, to his shiksha-guru Srila Bhakti Pramoda Puri and to all the disciples of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta, signing himself "servant of the servants of the Vaishnavas".

1. Our calendar (Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math) does not list his appearance day; the date follows one biography.

2. According to the same biography he was born in 1924, so in 1992 he was sixty-eight.